

Realism

By the mid-19th century, the Western world was experiencing profound changes, with industrialization and the rapid growth of towns, cities, populations and the middle classes. Particularly in France, a new generation of artists sought to express this modern world. Dutch artists had painted everyday realities in the 17th century, but influenced by photography, the new Realists took an even more direct approach. The academies, meanwhile, maintained that reality was not a suitable subject for art.

Some traces of realism emerged in the 17th and 18th century works of Velázquez and Goya, but the Realists were reacting to what they perceived as the excesses of Romanticism and Neoclassicism, the artificiality of Academic art, and the imperiousness of the academies. They also expressed their sympathies for the daily hardships of ordinary working people. Realists included Millet, Corot, Gustave Courbet, Honoré Daumier and Manet. The movement particularly inspired American painter Thomas Eakins (1844–1916).



Courbet, *The Stone Breakers*, 1849